our estimate is that India's requirement will be 3,000 pilots per year over the next 5-6 years." Even among the licences being issued each year, adds Hemanth, around 50 per cent are foreign ones converted to Indian CPLs. "So, in effect, we are producing only around 700-800 pilots every year," he says, "and the sad reality is that not all of them are employable."

If the pilot shortage is not appearing serious at the moment, it's only because new airline orders have been delayed due to supply chain constraints and more than 125 planes have been non-operational due to technical issues for months now, affecting carriers like IndiGo, Air India and SpiceJet. The Go First (formerly GoAir) fleet of 54 aircraft has also been grounded after it suspended operations completely in May 2023. "Currently, aircraft are grounded, new planes are delayed, and airlines have been working on their bench strength for a robust pilot pipeline," says Kapil Kaul, CEO of CAPA India. "But the shortage will start manifesting from FY27 onwards." IndiGo CEO Pieter Elbers has already indicated that 50 per cent of its grounded fleet will be back in business by early 2025.



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CEO, CAPA India

THE OTHER THREATS

These are not the only causes for worry for airlines. New regulations to address pilot fatigue could trigger a shortage of around 15 per cent, estimates CAPA India. There are limitations on how long a pilot can be kept on flight duty at a stretch. In January 2024, the DGCA came out with new norms—Flight Duty Time Limitation (FDTL)—to rationalise duty hours for pilots in India. Under these norms, weekly rest periods are to be increased from 36 hours to 48 hours for flight crew to give them sufficient time to recover from cumulative fatigue. The definition of 'night' has been amended to include an extra hour up to 6 am. It also mandates that airlines cannot ask a pilot to be on duty beyond the prescribed time limit. "Over the past five years, there have been many instances of pilots dying of heart attacks and stress. Even now, there are days when a pilot does 4-5 landings," claims Capt. Sam Thomas, president, Airline Pilots' Association of India (ALPA India).

If the airlines have breathing space, it's only because the new norms remain on paper for the moment. They have petitioned the DGCA for more time to prevent massive flight cancellations in view of staffing issues. In a mediation meeting on November 13, Air India reportedly informed the regulator that the new norms will hurt the interests of the cockpit crew as their flying hours and salaries will decrease. INDIA TODAY reached out to Air India for a comment, but the queries remained unanswered.

Another threat comes from poaching by bigger international carriers. Like in India, pilots are also a coveted resource in other countries where civil aviation is booming. The West Asian region, for instance, where the newly launched Riyadh Air, backed by deep pockets of the Saudi Arabian government, is seeking to employ 700 pilots over the next three years. The region is also home to some of the biggest airlines, be it Qatar Airways or the Dubai-based Emirates, which are in need of more pilots, according to a forecast by the global management consulting firm Oliver Wayman. The agency also estimates a worldwide shortage of around 80,000 pilots by 2032. A chunk of India's experienced crew, therefore, is likely to fly to greener pastures. "It's just a matter of time," warns Kaul.

THE PILOT PIPELINE

Over the past few years, the Indian government has been taking steps to augment pilot supply. Foremost among them has been the liberalisation of the Flying Training Organisations (FTO) policy. Earlier, the Airports Authority of India (AAI) would take a share of the revenue of the flying schools as airport royalty to let them use its facilities. That has been abolished. It has also lowered the rentals on its land. Following this shift, the government claims that India's pilot training landscape expanded significantly in 2021-22, with 15 new flying schools opening across 10 regional airports. This has taken the number of such schools in the country to 37. Besides the Centre's IGRUA, four are owned by state governments—Bihar, Gujarat, Telangana and Madhya Pradesh—four are registered societies and the rest are commercial institutes.

Global players have sensed the opportunity. "Despite such remarkable growth, India is facing a critical pilot shortage, and the rapid growth of the aviation sector demands high-quality training," says Marijus Ravoitis, chief executive officer, BAA Training Aviation Academy, a multinational aviation training company expanding its footprint in India with local partnerships. BAA opened its third consultancy centre in Bengaluru in October and has tied up with banks to secure 100 per cent loans for aspiring pilots to fund the course that costs around Rs 1.16 crore.

In comparison, IGRUA charges Rs 45 lakh for its two-year course. But Pragya Priyadarshini, vice president of the consultancy firm Primus Partners, feels airlines should consider partnering with educational institutions to make pilot training programmes more accessible through sponsorships and scholarships. It has, in fact, become an urgent imperative. For, on November 17, more than 500,000 domestic passengers took off across the country in a single day, the highest ever. ■